Chapter 18

Innovation and Ingenuity: Reforms Take Form

THERE WAS AN URGENT NEED TO INTERACT WITH THE PRISONERS, FOR IT was they who would be the beneficiaries of any schemes launched. A very imaginative innovation was introduced in the form of the *petition box*. The usual practice of suggestion boxes proved ineffective because of the inherent flaws in the system. The keys to the earlier box would be with the jail staff, who would intercept and destroy any complaints against them. In the new system the petition (or complaint and suggestion) box had been made mobile. A constable appointed by headquarters carried this box around the jail on his bicycle during the prisoners' free time. The keys to the box were with a gazetted officer at HQ, who sorted out the petitions according to their nature. The main points were listed for the IG (P)'s perusal, after which, a pink acknowledgement card was sent to the petitioner. Expeditious inquiries, where necessary, were conducted and, within a week, the petitioner received a green card that stated the action taken, or conclusions drawn. If any such case required more time, then such information also was communicated to the petitioner within a week.

'The petitions informed me of what exactly happened inside,' said Kiran. 'The complaints ranged from lack of amenities, quality of food, need for medical aid to harassment by jail staff and the use of corrupt practices. In fact, one head warder was shifted on the basis of one such complaint. The complainant pointed out how this warder was beating prisoners like animals. The petitioner's identity was kept confidential if he or she so required or if the petition officer felt it necessary on grounds of security. This system resulted in the diversion of petitions from the high courts to the jail administration and provided several advantages. For instance, it reduced the workload of the court, saved time on legal representations and vastly improved the quality of supervision.'

Supplementing this system in Tihar was another, namely, that of the panchayat or forum. (A panchayat is normally made up of five members.)

'This forum,' explained Deputy Superintendent Sunil Gupta, 'comprised representatives from each barrack and we had a daily sitting with them. This was our main link through which we could implement new ideas and programmes. The "panchayat" members suggested changes and schemes and we gave them a good hearing. If found feasible, we tried to incorporate them. Now since it was these members themselves who suggested them, it was not difficult at all to implement them in their respective barracks. And two juvenile wards, or *Munda Khanas*, named the "Kambli Ward" and the "Sachin Ward" [after the famous cricketers Vinod Kambli and Sachin Tendulkar] were opened in July 1993.'

'There were 1000 teenagers in these wards,' further informed the deputy superintendent. 'These were the potential criminals and if we could do something to make them appreciate the difference between right and wrong and to make them utilize their energies constructively, then that would have